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God Oversees Your Nothings

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Free media and discipleship resources for pastors, leaders, and growing disciples.

God Oversees Your Nothings

Today's Reading: John 21:1-3

Hearing God's Voice for Today:

"Simon Peter said to them, 'I am going fishing.' They said to him, 'We will go with you.' They went out and got into the boat, but that night they caught nothing."

* * * * *

John wrote about Jesus' third resurrection appearance in his Gospel. There were many others, but the three John presented were the ones he chose to emphasize.

The disciples had returned to Galilee, where, as Mark noted, Jesus had commanded them to go and wait for him. Jesus had promised that he would go before them. If you are his disciple, that should be encouraging news for you. There is no place to where you go that he is not already there waiting for you.

The disciples waited patiently to see if Jesus would appear to them again. Peter was especially discouraged. He was dealing with his guilt, grief, and shame over having denied Jesus three times. He was in great need of the Lord's grace.

While the disciples waited, they started fishing again. That was natural for them to do. When someone is feeling uncertain about something in life, he often returns to what he knows he can do well. For some of the disciples, this meant their fishing business. That's what they had devoted their lives to when Jesus called them to follow him.

The disciples went out in a boat at night, which was the preferred time to fish. It was cooler, so the fish weren't swimming along the bottom. Also, when fish were caught at night, they could be sold quickly and easily in the market the next morning while still fresh. The disciples were skilled fishermen, and they knew what they were doing.

But this night, the disciples caught nothing. They repeatedly threw their nets over one side of the boat, then the other, but without success. They were completely shut out. Nothing worked for them.

At the time, the disciples didn't realize this truth: Jesus oversees all "nothings." This was all part of his perfect plan to help them receive his love and mission for them—especially Peter. As they saw Jesus make their nothing into something, their faith in him would increase.

In just a little bit, it would all make sense to them.

When nothing seems to be working for you, you need to trust that Jesus is the Lord of your nothings. When nothing seems to be happening in your life, trust him. It's not a surprise to him. He oversees all— even when nothing seems to be happening.

Jesus is using your nothings for a larger purpose. Sometimes he wants to exhaust you of all your human strength so you'll depend solely on him. Other times he doesn't want you to depend on what you do really well, but depend completely on him.

If it seems like nothing is working for you right now, rejoice! Trust him. He knows what he is doing. Faith continues to trust God when nothing seems to be happening.

He is the Lord of your nothings.

[from *"Hearing the Voice of God"* by Pastor David Chadwick, Moments of Hope Church, Charlotte, NC]